secrets? How did he have access to the documents he copied? Would the leaks hurt national security? These were some of the questions shocked government officials, members of the media, and the public asked in the following days and months as many top-secret documents Snowden leaked came to light. The documents revealed programs in which the NSA had collected phone and online data from millions of customers of telecom and Internet companies. Other

WHISTLE-BLOWERS

Whistle-blowers are corporate or government employees who release confidential information suggesting their employer is involved in some kind of fraud, corruption, or threat to the public. One of the most famous US whistle-blowers is Daniel Ellsberg, a former military analyst. He became convinced the US government was lying to the public about the Vietnam War (1955–1975). In 1969, he handed more than 7,000 photocopies of classified documents to the *New York Times* and other publications.[2] The Pentagon Papers leak helped contribute to the war's end. Ellsberg was tried for disclosing classified documents, but the case was dismissed in 1973. More recently, Army Private Chelsea Manning, formerly Bradley Manning, was sentenced in August 2013 to 35 years in prison for leaking hundreds of thousands of secret defense-related documents to the website WikiLeaks.

Various US laws protect most government whistle-blowers, but not in all situations. For example, members of the military, such as Manning, must follow military regulations in addition to federal laws. Snowden maintains he is not eligible for protection under US whistle-blower laws because he was an employee of a private contractor, not a direct employee of the NSA.

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